

The Supposed Autographa of John the Scot

Edward Kennard Rand

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JOHN THE SCOT ***

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THE SUPPOSED AUTOGRAPH OF JOHN THE SCOT

BY

EDWARD KENNARD RAND

In the fifth part of Ludwig Traube's *Palaeographische Forschungen*, (which I had the honor of publishing after that great scholar's death)^[1] evidence was presented for Traube's apparently certain discovery of the very handwriting of John the Scot. In manuscripts of Reims, of Laon, and of Bamberg, he had observed certain marginal notes which were neither omitted sections nor glosses, but rather the author's own amplifications and embellishments of his work. Johannes had made such additions to his *De Divisione Naturae* in the Reims manuscript, and they all appear in that of Bamberg. In the latter manuscript there are fresh additions—or enlargements as I shall call them in the present paper—which have similarly been absorbed into the text in two manuscripts now in Paris. We thus have, in an interesting series, the author's successive recensions of his work. One of the shorter forms is the basis of the text published by Thomas Gale in 1681; the most complete form was edited by H. J. Floss in 1852 from the Paris manuscripts.^[2] Though not venturing to carry out Traube's elaborate plans for treatment of the subject, I attempted to corroborate his belief that the notes were in the hand of Johannes. The evidence seemed conclusive to me at the time, and was not questioned, so far as I know, in any subsequent publication. In the summers of 1912 and 1913, however, I examined the manuscripts of John the Scot in Paris, in Reims, in Laon, and in Bamberg, and became convinced, most reluctantly, that his autograph is yet to be found. I here present the chain of facts that make this conclusion inevitable.^[3]

Let us start with the hypothesis that the marginal notes discovered by Traube are in the hand of Johannes himself and let us support this hypothesis until it becomes too heavy to bear. Our first document is the Reims Manuscript 875 (= *R*) of the *De Divisione Naturae*. This is the work of some six or seven writers, whose hands are sometimes hard to tell apart. Though it is the briefest and hence the earliest form of the text that I have found, it is not the original draft of the work. The scribes could not have taken it from the author's dictation, for they commit errors of various sorts that presuppose the existence of a text that they were copying.^[4] This text, which is as near to the original as our present information permits us to come, I will call *O*.

Besides making corrections and additions in their copy of *O*, the scribes also insert marginal notes that have all the characteristics of the author's own amplifications of his work. This fact does not militate against our present hypothesis, if we assume that Johannes added these marginalia, or caused them to be added, in *O*, and that the scribes of *R*, at first forgetting to include them in the text of their new copy, later wrote them in the margin.^[5] In some cases, as we might expect, a different ink is used. The insular hand (= *I*), which we are assuming to be that of Johannes, corrects minor errors in these enlargements now and then.^[6] This fact is entirely in accord with our hypothesis.

A number of enlargements omitted by the writers of the text were supplied not by them but by special correctors, who were assigned, it would seem, considerable portions of the manuscript to revise. Particularly important among these wide-ranging correctors are two hands that I will call r^1 and r^2 . The former is a largish hand with some slight traces of Insular habits.^[7] r^2 is very similar, and indeed may be merely a smaller variety of r^1 . In the specimen that I have reproduced, as is true of both r^1 and r^2 elsewhere, correction by *I* may be observed.^[8] In all, I detected, or thought I detected, five or six correcting hands, which sometimes supplement stretches of text written by

others, sometimes supplement their own text, and, in all the cases under discussion, add notes of the author which were evidently in the margin of *O*. It is sometimes hard to be sure whether *r* is the text-hand or not. The point is not vitally important. The main fact is that several different kinds of correcting hand make, either in their own texts or in those of others, the kind of additions or enlargements with which we are specially concerned. However, as we have seen, we can still retain our hypothesis by supposing that *I* is the hand of Johannes, while *r* represents various correctors who copied from *O* enlargements added there by Johannes or at his direction.

But we have now to note an intimate connection between *I* and *r*. They collaborate on the same notes. Plate V (fol. 285^v) shows us an enlargement that begins in the hand (= *r*³) that writes the text. It extends through *substantiam* (1.3), then is succeeded by *I* (*ex his—horum est*), then returns (*Ibi—superans*), and finally gives way to *I* once more (*dum—esse*). The interesting possibility and enlargements taken from *O*. Possibly two or more stages are represented by *O*, *r* starting with an earlier, and *I* supplementing from a more complete form—but into that *terra incognita* of fresh hypothesis we need not enter. *I*'s procedure, at any rate, seems exactly like that of *r*. Thus his practice of calling in a variety of *r* to complete a note too large for the space is paralleled by *r*⁴, the writer of the text on fol. 231^v (Plate II), who uses up a legitimate amount of his margin and then has *r*⁵ finish it, with signs of references, on the following page. The latter scribe uses a finer hand, and has no difficulty in completing the note with a decent margin to spare.^[9]

Surely in the scribal play illustrated in Plate V, *I* is acting more like a fellow-worker than the author of the work. Likewise on another page, we note corrections and minor enlargements by the text-hand, then similar changes by *I*, and, finally, corrections of *I* by the text-hand.^[10] If Johannes wished to change *cogitationes* to *operationes*, it is strange that he did not do it himself rather than beckon to some scribe to insert the word; another correction, *nisi*, added above the line, is made in the hand of *I*. In short, *r* and *I* are two different scribes collaborating on what would appear to be a rather difficult original or set of originals.

Moreover, if *I* is Johannes, he does not understand his own text. In *De Divisione Naturae* i. 49 (Migne *P.L.* cxxii, 491 A) we read:

Omnium hominum una eademque ουσια est. Omnes enim unam participant essentiam, ac per hoc, quia omnibus communis est, nullius proprie est. Corpus autem commune omnium hominum non est. Nam unusquisque suum proprium possidet corpus, non et ουσιαν. Igitur communis est, et corpus commune non est.

This passage forms part of one of the enlargements of *I*. In it he writes *omnis* for *omnes*, and *Non et ουσιαε igitur communis est* for *non et ουσιαν. Igitur communis est*. These are understandable errors for any scribe, but not for the author of the work, to make. Others occur elsewhere in the Insular hand; I have not recorded many, but I made no systematic search.

We now come to the most startling consideration of all, namely, that *there are two varieties of insular script in the book*. The first variety, which I will now call *i*¹, is exhibited in all the plates thus far presented. It is loose, pointed, flowing, with few abbreviations or ligatures specially characteristic of Irish script. With only one or two exceptions, it uses a *d* with a curved shaft. The other variety (*i*²), as Plate X (fol. 106) shows, is at once more compact and regular, and more cursive, with more of the specifically Irish traits; it has a straight-shafted *d*. Furthermore, the two hands appear in different portions of the manuscript. *i*¹ is confined to foll. 1-80^v (= quires I-X) and foll. 113-318^v (= quires XV-XLI), while *i*² appears only in foll. 81-112^v (= quires XI-XIV) and

foll. 319-358 (= quires XLII-XLVI). In the sections corrected by i^2 , we note the same features as in the other parts. i^2 inserts many long enlargements and makes many minor corrections. He is supplemented in one of his own enlargements by r^2 .^[11] On another page, he is corrected by r^2 , or possibly the text-hand.^[12]

Our last resort, if we are still to look for the autograph of John the Scot in the various hands of Reims, is to suppose that, if not i^1 , it is i^2 . This is indeed the hand that Traube believed was the author's; it happened that almost all of the photographs taken for Traube contain enlargements by i^2 and not by i^1 . Yet if i^2 is Johannes, why does that hand never correct the sections assigned to i^1 ? Of the two, i^1 seems more free, more individual, more like an author's, unless that author be also a calligraphist. But if we imagine that i^1 is Johannes, why does he never appear in the sections assigned to i^2 ?

Our chain of evidence draws us to the conclusion that neither i^1 nor i^2 is Johannes, but that both are scribes employed by him, together with others, to correct and enlarge the manuscripts of his works. The two Insular writers were very possibly the most important of his workmen, for he entrusted most of the revision to them. Their task was done in intimate coöperation with the other scribes. They would call them in to finish their notes if considerations of space demanded, or, now and then, merely to indulge in a pastime of alternate writing. Perhaps it was the difficulty of deciphering the original that induced a scribe to appeal more frequently than usual for help from a fellow-craftsman. I have confined my discussion to the manuscript 875 of Reims, but the two Insular hands appear also in the manuscripts of Bamberg and of Laon.^[13]

After all is said and done, the great value of Traube's discovery remains. It is positive that the enlargements in the manuscripts were made at the direction of the author himself. They present to the modern editor of the *De Divisione Naturae* the fascinating task of distinguishing the different revisions, and of following the growth of the subject in Johannes' mind. The best way, I believe, would be to print on the left-hand page the enlarged form of the text, for that is the form in which the author wished his work to be known to posterity. On the right-hand page, the briefest form, the nearest approach to his original draft, might be given, with indication, in the critical apparatus, of the successive stages by which the final text was reached. Possibly further research may reveal *O*, or even the hand of Johannes himself. For the present, we at least have accessible—if the contents of the libraries of Reims and of Laon are accessible—the material for preparing a highly accurate and well-nigh unique edition of one of the masterpieces of medieval philosophy.

FOOTNOTES:

[1] In Abh. d. k. b. Akad. d. Wiss., philos.-philol. u. hist. Classe, München, XXVI (1912).

[2] In Migne, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. 122 (1865).

[3] I have confined my illustrations almost entirely to passages exhibited in the plates. I have notes of many other examples quite as pertinent, but do not include them here, believing that those presented amply prove my point.

[4] For an example, see Plate I (fol. 273). In the last regular line of the page, after writing *caelestis essentiae particeps est*, the scribe first omitted the words *de die*—*caelestis essentiae particeps est* (an exceedingly easy haplography) and then added them, with signs of reference, in the margin immediately below. As the error is one of sight and not of hearing, he must have had a text before him.

[5] Plate II (fol. 231^v) contains a striking instance. After the citation of St. Basil, the author bethinks him of another possible interpretation of his words (*An aliud ex uerbis ipsius—intelligendum*) and sets it forth

in the enlargement. It is not probable, I believe, that the author dictated this forthwith to the scribe. As the existence of *O* has been proved, it is more natural to assume that the enlargement had already been inserted there.

[6] E.g., fol. 59 (I have no photograph). The added *quodam* in l.10 of fol. 231 (Plate II) is not by *I*. See below, note 10. *Ut arbitror* in the right margin seems exactly the thing that an author tucks in when revising and qualifying his work. But see below p. 138.

[7] Plate III contains a specimen (fol. 64). At first this hand looks like that of the text, but it is really different. The corrections are, I believe, by *r*¹ himself. They had been made in *O*, I infer, but at first were not observed by *r*¹. The heading *De agere et pati* is by a hand of the thirteenth century or later (= *h*).

[8] See Plate IV (fol. 15). As in the previous specimen, this hand is similar to that of the text, but not identical with it. The hand *h* adds three headings.

[9] Fol. 232 (Plate VIII). *r*⁵ then collated the work of *r*⁴ with *O*, adding *quodam* in l.10, and perhaps correcting *consequentius* to *consequentias* in l.12.

[10] Fol. 58^v (Plate IX).

[11] See fol. 81, Plate XI (= Plate I in *Pal. Forsch.*).

[12] Fol. 106 (Plate X).

[13] For *i*² in the Bamberg MS, see *Pal. Forsch.*, Plates III-VIII. For *i*¹ in the Laon MS, see *Pal. Forsch.*, Plate X.

PLATES

Plate I. Fol. 273.

Plate II. Fol. 231^v.

Plate III. Fol. 64.

Plate IV. Fol. 15.

Plate V. Fol. 285^v.

Plate VI. Fol. 49.

Plate VII. Fol. 56.

Plate VIII. Fol. 232.

Plate IX. Fol. 58^v.

Plate X. Fol. 106.

Plate XI. Fol. 81 (= *Pal. Forsch.*, Plate I).

alia homo iudicat omnia ipse uero a nemine diiudicatur. Intuere quā clare quam
 apte hominem uelut in duos homines diuidit. quorum unus quidē animalis est
 quā natura animalium ^{similis} consistit, quod omni huiusmodi spirituum in se recipit, alter uero
 spiritus alius quā aeternis et spiritibus diuinisq; communiter subsistentis totiusq; ani-
 malitatis se perit, ecce quidē pars qua animal ē exterioris hominis caetero
 quā superat caetera animalia et seipsū in quantum animal ē interioris congrue
 appellatione corpus huiusmodi quod spiritus alius et uiuunt ut utique accipit, exterior
 homo corrumpit interior uero de die in diem renouatur quoniam perfecte uiuunt
 in eo corpus suū et uitā quā illud administrat omnisq; corporales sensus eū
 his quae per se percipit omnisq; irrationabiles motus quos in se sentit cū omniū
 rerū mutabilium memoria nō solum spernit uerū etiā quantum potest et cor-
 rumpit et ceteris ne ullomodo in eo quāleant et comminatio perire eis et ceteris
 appetit seipsū uero in quantum ceteris et sentit participat, in mentis uitam
 de die in diem hoc ē de uirtute in uirtute ascendens diuina gratia mouente cooperante
 diuina efficacia renouatur ecce quidē natura quā animalibus homo communiter carod
 caetero quā ceteris essentiae participat etc.

PLATE 1

nulla corporum transitoria ueluti inchoante terra luce demum datam
 absque illa quae tegebatur in congregatione una collecta: haec enim
 omnia eccae terra quae descripta primordialis dierum operibus; diuina
 scriptura commemorat simul et semel diuino precepto absque ullis tem-
 poralibus inter uallis suis rationibus secundum quas conditas distancas
 effecta fuisse et in speciebus suas producta beatus simus perspexit. ^{ut ait beatus}
 filius. **N**. Iuste recteque magni uirum predicat nec aliter de ipso est
 sententia dum. **P**ulchre igitur segregata mutabilitate accidentium
 stabilitate substantiae multiplex ipsius uis per diuersas species
 uerbis in parte uisibiliter erupit herbarum lignorumque significationibus insinuat
 acuratur etiam. **O**mnis enim species in genere eodemque in substantia naturaliter
 operans et in fine quiescit donec mundus consumatur; utque sphaera cum ab aliquo impellitur
 sepe cluso accipiat obliqua conformatione eodem modo in regione ferè impellente prius fuit
 quae aequaliter corporum ipsa suscipiat. sic natura quae contra uno precepto mota in generatione
 corruptione creatur a plene parte. Generum consequentia similitudine saluatur donec ad prius
 distendat finem. Equi quidem equi facit. Successorem leonem leonem. Aquilam aquile. Remque
 animalium consequentia successorem bus conseruatum utque summatione uniuscuiusque animalis.

PLATE 2

1. hoc. uident in se pater. Ipse enim omnia quae sunt
 in seipso uidet. nihil autem extra seipsum aspiciat
 quia nihil extra seipsum est. cum uero augustinus
 de hoc dederit currens recte intel-
 ligatur. Ipse enim in omnia currit. et nullo mo-
 do facit sed omnia currendo implet. sicut scrip-
 tum est. uolocat currere sermo eius. et tam nullo modo
 uerissime dicitur motus stabilis et fixus mobi-
 lis. fixus enim in seipso incommutabiliter. puer
 quam naturalem suam stabilitatem deserens.
 2. mouet autem seipsum per omnia ut sint ea quae se
 essentialiter subsistunt. mouentur ipsius omnia
 sunt. A. De etymologia nominis facti ac
 probabiliter suum esse. sed non facti uideo
 quod moueat quicunque est sine quo nihil esse
 potest et extra quem nihil extenditur. est enim
 locus omnium atque circum scriptus. I. dicitur moueri

hoc est quod
 sic non uidetur
 quod nihil sit in ipso

mouetur
 dicitur si quis
 dicitur

sic mouetur
 motu dicitur

hoc mouetur
 ubi est anima
 quae nihil est

3. Ac hoc unus est idemque intellectus in uerbis et in rebus.
 eiusdem nominis quod est dicitur. non alius dicitur rebus omnia quae ui-
 dentur. sed in seipso mouendo in seipso mouendo suum omnia.

¶ Nec uero aliquid diffiniunt hominem non secundum quod intelligitur esse sed ex his quae circa eum intelliguntur
 dicentes homo est animal rationale mortale sensus & disciplinæ capax. & quod est mirabilis huius diffinitione
 ostendit uocari dum non sit substantialis sed circa substantiam ex qua personatione personae accidunt.
 Ex primis assumptis
 notio namque hominis
 in mente diuina non
 est hominis sed. Ibi sapientia
 simpliciter ne hoc per illud
 dicitur. Omne diffinitum in mente diuina deum in se facit. & uerissima et perfectissima diffinitio
 rationis et collectionem
 partium superant. In
 de deum et tunc
 per deum et tunc
 quid sit. Ibi dicitur
 de uero & si ad diffi
 nitionem est quod solummodo
 affirmat. Et tunc
 quod quid est.
 Nunc ab illis deum per ueritatem omnium sensibilibus et intelligibilibus quae potentia humana
 non intelligitur notione quanta in homine est. & uidetur plane quod
 hoc maxime cum eorum quae sunt de qualitate sibi creatas siue quibus dominari pre
 cipit deum est et habere; quomodo enim dominatus eorum homini daretur quorum
 notione non haberet siquidem dominatus illius erraret si ea quae regeret non haberet.
 quod aptissime diuina nobis indicat scriptura dicens formatus est deus deus de homine
 amicus amicitias; terrae et uniuersis uolantibus; caeli adduxit ea ad adam et
 uideret quid uocaret ea. amicus quod uocauit adam animae uniuersae ipsius
 & nomen illius uidetur inquit hoc est ut intelligat quid uocaret. si enim in

PLATE 5

necesse seu quaecumque circumscriptionis speciem qua uniuscuius
 q; substantia ambitur. Inter ea quae sensibus corporis succum
 bunt recte sapienter posuerit, cum uideat terminos lineae seu tri-
 anguli seu alicuius planae solidaeue figurae incorporeos esse punctus siquidem ex
 similiter q; naturalium corporum siue sensibilia sine p[er]contem-
 perantiam elementorum quibus subsistunt siue subtilitate sui
 mortales fugiant contuius solo intellectu naturae fines per
 quos omnia materiae componuntur et in componenda est.
 spiciuntur. **N** Itaq; ingenere inuisibilium diffinitiones
 quas locos rerum circumscripserunt diximus concludi arbi-
 trario. **I**ta quidem arbitror et nunc certius uideo. **S**i
 Recte aestimas sed quia iterum genus inuisibilium in multas
 species diuidi patitur quaedam enim inuisibilia sunt quae intelli-
 guntur et intelligunt quaedam intelligunt et non intelligunt
 incorporea est et est finis lineae principium uero soliditatis. soliditas quoque incor-
 poreae est et est finis totius personae. quicquid enim in his id est punctus sua
 linea siue superficiem siue soliditatem componit. sensus ad id est. propter
 figurae incorporeae rerum est. nec enim ipsa uero substantia quae in
 corporea est.

PLATE 6

corpus autem efficiunt quodammodo non accipimus quod admodum
 mus accipere naturalis ne ad oycia reverti videamur. haec de
 dictu est ut has singulas regulas in geometria corporibus statuimus
 et conficiamus. In quibus haec tria separata discreta esse potest inna
 turalibus autem inseparabiliter cohaerent in quibus solo intellectu
 quaritas ab oycia separata. Nam cum deus quis de quantitate dis
 putare tanquam de oycia quid diceret putaret confundere. scit de
 his dictu esse recte. *Sed* plane sed recte ut uideo ut de ipsa ma
 teria formaque quibus materialia corpora componi differit pauca edis
 serui. non praetercundum est ut utriusque siquidem nihil scire duces
 ut uideatur forma et quae generi subdit et quae materiae ut con
 pulsit capulatur. *H* fortis maru aliae in oycia aliae in qualitate *sed differunt formam*
 intelliguntur. sed quae in oycia substantiales species generis sunt quae de
 uidentur quid sunt in oycia magister dicit cum uidet inquit quis de quanti
 tate hoc est de spaciis quibus corpus conficitur disputa ut ab his qui nil aliud est
 oycia affirmant nisi corpus quod uidetur de ipsa oycia putat quid dicitur.
 Singula geometria corpora quae sola animo tractu contemplamur solique memorie imaginatione
 frangere curamus in aliqua oycia subsistunt perfectae ne curam nullam in geometria et naturalia
 corpora differuntur quia uero quae geometria corpora solo animo consideramus

Et si nemo pnt eptoloni pcedat. Incolloqui huc fecit affirmare spiritum
 domini quod prophetam nuncupat cupit scire quod qd xpi nō quidem prophetia
 inu. non pnt nisi p pnt pnt de uerbo incarnato dicitur bina et quā mptu si actus
 quod qd dicitur huc n pnt domini pnt p xpm. pnt aut domi nō pnt p pnt xpi
 lōe sps diuinitas et dicitur huc dicitur omni charitate uerbi et inuicibz domi qd dicitur
 generalituar alii in pntatione linguar. Oia aut huc oportet dicitur uerbo
 unus atq. id est p diuinitas pnta unicuique pnt uerbo; huc et dicitur pnta
 generatōe possunt argumētari ubi dicitur et dicitur di fouet aquas
 ad quidem aliud dicitur dicitur et dicitur di pnta diuinitas aut a nūm
 aquas fouet focundat. nūm dicitur si uerbo qd uniformitatem unūq.
 ac si m pntia in uerbo facta p differētia generū format. et dicitur
 ac pnta nūm dicitur qd omniū dicitur dicitur acque ordinat. Et
 pnta mptu dicitur charitē prophetā candelabri uerbo dicitur dicitur
 dicitur significat; lapis uerbo dicitur dicitur pnta nūm dicitur dicitur
 qd illuminat omē hominē uerbo in mundū dicitur dicitur xpi quicquid
 dicitur in pnta carnis natura. Et conceptus dicitur dicitur. Et pnta in mundo
 sup can dicitur dicitur lapis dicitur dicitur pnta in pnta dicitur dicitur
 fctia let sapientia dicitur dicitur. sup quē primo scdm intelligentia humanitatis
 al. caput quippe uniuersi cor. pnt dicitur dicitur. donationes scī sps quae dicitur

PLATE 10

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